CHAPTER SIX

Fusing Horizons

IT WOULD HELP here, perhaps, to attempt another summary of the main line of our argument, and in this way to bring out another dimension of the view of human agency we are proposing.

We identified above (Chapter 1) one of the main motivations for the turn to mediational epistemologies, starting with Descartes. This turn is powered by a sense of good critical method. In order to challenge established views, you may have to make what is merely taken as granted explicit; it may be very useful to break some claim down into its component elements, or the separable bits of evidence it relies on; it may be essential to split a merely factual claim from a questionable valuation, or to make a sharp distinction between our take on things and the way they really are.

All this is very true and often crucially important. The basic error was to ontologize this method, to conclude that because this is often the good way to think, it is somehow the way the mind always works, so that we are supposed always to be taking in bits of explicit, neutral information, and combining them. Only we often do this sloppily, inattentively, or too much under the spell of some external authority, and we need to be called back to a more careful, reflective construction.

Against this, our claim has been that in fact our original way of being in the world, coping with reality, finding our way about, reflects a kind of understanding in which none of these distinctions between explicit, analytical elements figure, no more than those between fact and value, or belief and reality.[1] Ontologizing method, reading the explicit, atomic bits of neutral information back into our everyday commerce with the world, not only distorts our everyday reality, but hides from us what an achievement critique is. We fail to see how it requires a shift in our stance to the world, disengaging ourselves from the ordinary meanings of things, decentering ourselves from our involvements in our surroundings.

The Heideggerian term "primordial" (*ursprünglich*) has been used to make this point. Ordinary, engaged coping is primordial, not only because it is in fact our first way of being in the world, which we can never wholly abandon, but also because the decentered, critical stance can only arise from within this ordinary way of being, suspending it completely in relation to our objects of study, but always relying on our everyday coping skills.

Of course, one can understand the motivation for this ontologization. To start with, the whole foundational enterprise is hopeless unless we can dig down to rock-bottom bits of explicit evidence, on which the edifice of science can be reared. This undoubtedly must have weighed with the pioneers of the tradition, like Descartes and Locke. But even after foundationalism is abandoned, the hope for total clarity about human reasoning, and/or for a clear scientific account of it, continues to confer a premium on the atomic and the explicit. We can see this with computer-inspired models of human thinking which have been popular in our age. These too require computation on explicit bits of information, and have no place for the (gestalt) holism of our being in the world. And certain modes of critique base themselves on the (unfounded) belief that factual premises can always be split from evaluative ones in our deliberations.

Now another feature of good method, at least from Descartes' point of view, was that it forced us back onto our own judgement, each to his or her own. We cannot take these matters on authority, but each of us must be assured that the basis of our thinking is really clear and distinct, and that the chains of argument are so as well. There is an animus in this line of thinking against taking things from established tradition, or on external

authority. We are called in the end to be "self-responsible" in our critical thought.[1]

This feature of critical method, valid as it often is, has been ontologized, so that it is assumed that the primary subject of knowledge is the individual. And this too has generated an immense distortion of the human condition. We cannot go into the full significance of this here; that would require at least another book. But some aspects of it are directly relevant to our argument.

Once we realize that critique is only possible through a shift in our stance, and once we reflect that shifts of this kind develop and enter our repertory with the evolution of human culture, we see right away that it is a huge and potentially fatal oversimplification to think that critique is simply realized in and by self-responsible individuals. True, it is sometimes the case that one person stands out against an erroneous consensus (and our modern Western culture has tended to celebrate this kind of case); and it may happen that such a heroic figure may even invent a new kind of critique; Socrates, Descartes, and Kant can be seen as examples. But even the most innovative move, which adds something new to our historical repertory of critical stances, doesn't come ex nihilo; it builds on the already established modes; and even the heroic innovator had first to be trained and socialized into these, before striking out on his or her own. How much more do we ordinary followers need to receive the tools of our own critical work from our culture?

These various stances of disengagement or of decentering are developed in language, which shows here as elsewhere a crucial articulative function. Language not only serves to describe what we have already identified and singled out, but can also be used to give expression to new ways of talking, thinking, questioning—and therefore bring them for the first time into our repertory. Socrates is once again a paradigm example, honored in our tradition. We now have (partly thanks to Plato as well) a new word, "dialectic"; but this doesn't serve to describe a preexisting reality; rather this word serves to focus our awareness of a novel kind of questioning exchange, which was

1. The expression is Edmund Husserl's, from a passage in his *Krisis* lectures in which he identifies, across all the differences, with the fundamental stance of Descartes. For Descartes' own attitude to established authorities, see the negative reference to "our desires and preceptors" (*nos appétits et nos précepteurs*) in the *Discours de la Méthode* (Paris: Flammarion, 2000); for Locke's, see the introduction to *Essay Concerning Human Understanding*.

born along with it. Similarly, "idea" comes to be used in a new way by Descartes, with a new technical sense, to designate something which didn't figure in people's self-understandings previously, a basic unit of information, purely in the "mind." Kant also widens our repertory in giving the term "critical" itself a new and specialized meaning.[2]

These great thinkers gave us new concepts; but we shouldn't simply focus on these. It is not just that our repertory of description has been enriched, in the way a good botanist, for instance, can enrich it. What we have been given are new ways of carrying through criticism together. New moves arose within existing forms of conversation, which ended up transforming these conversations. Before Socrates, Athenians certainly argued about what was really just or pious, but the turn to a collaborative but agonistic search for a definition which would not collapse into incoherence was a new (and maddening) mode of continuing the argument, a new direction of inquiry. Against the whole atomist thrust of the mediational position, we have to remember the primacy of the conversation here, both the matrix in which the new move could be made, and the transformed kinds of exchange which it enables and which flow from it.

This point has been made in the last century in a host of ways. Wittgenstein has shown how we cannot grasp the meanings of certain terms unless we see how they figure in the (social) language games they arise in. And these games in turn need to be placed within the whole *Lebensform* they help to constitute.[3] Others have pointed out that in order to understand a given use of a concept, or the sentences in which it figures, we have to identify the genre of discourse in which it occurs. Construal cannot be of single sentences; we need to know the "text" in which they are embedded. And many of the genres of "text" are in fact exchanges, conversations in which, for instance, the reference of the pronouns in one "speech" passes through the referring expression occurring in others.

This foregrounding of the primacy of conversation, of the language games of critique over the individual moves of disengagement or decentering into a critical mode, enriches the understanding of human agency

2. For a further discussion of this expressive-constitutive function of language, see Charles Taylor, "The Importance of Herder," in *Philosophical Arguments* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1995), 79–99.

3. Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophische Untersuchungen*.

which we need to recover from the mediational distortion. In the Heideggerian language invoked above, primordial agency, in its engaged coping, operates within a repertory which is shared; the agent is not first an individual, but one among others, whose joint participation within shared forms is essential—even in establishing that segment of my repertory in which I can come to function alone.

Underlying our explicit, decentered, disengaged, even solitary thinking is a more basic contact with reality, not only with the world with which we are at grips, but also with those others who are at grips with it together with ourselves.

What emerges from the brief discussion in the preceding paragraphs, is that there are two main avenues of refutation of the mediational view, which we outlined at the beginning of Chapter 2. In general, in Chapters 2 to 5, we have been following the first axis of refutation, that which challenges the centrality of mental representations to knowledge. But this leaves untouched the second line of argument, which targets the monological focus of traditional mediational theory. Mediationalism, from Descartes on, as we have just seen, is partly powered by a sense of what good method is; and this method is understood as paradigmatically monological, carried out by and in individual minds. But now it is time to take up the second theme in the above paragraphs, and underline the primacy of conversation in human linguistic life. The methods and forms of critique, the ones we draw on and operate within, are established first in our culture. True, some of us are Socrateses, and help to originate hitherto unknown forms, but these only become part of the heritage of our successors because they are taken up by the culture we bequeath to them.

In Chapter 6 we will be operating clearly on this second track.

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As we've just noted, a very important area in which we want to distinguish something like scheme and content is where we are dealing with the very different "takes" of very different cultures on nature and the human condition. Here as well, the view we have been defending cannot allow that these differences are insurmountable or inescapable. The embedded view, in fact,

offers resources for recognizing differences of scheme, without generating arguments for nonrealism. The conception of the knowing agent at grips with the world opens possibilities quite different from those available on the mediational view. There may be (and obviously are) differences, alternative takes on and construals of reality, which may even be systematic and far-reaching. Some of these will be, all may be, wrong. But any such take or construal is within the context of a basic engagement with/understanding of the world, a contact with it which cannot be broken off short of death. It is impossible to be totally wrong. Even if, after climbing the path, I think myself to be in the wrong field, I have situated myself in the right county, I know the way back home, etc. The reality of contact with the real world is the inescapable fact of human (or animal) life, and can only be imagined away by erroneous philosophical argument. And it is in virtue of this contact with a common world that we always have something to say to each other, something to point to in disputes about reality.

How are we to understand this possibility of communication? We can think of it on two levels. First of all, in virtue of the way we are all as human beings in contact with the world through engaged coping, we share something important. We all have to find our feet within the boundary conditions of the same world, on the basis of the same kind of bodies, basic capacities, and so on. Moreover, we all share the same basic needs: food, clothes, shelter, rest, and the like. This virtually ensures that when we enter a new culture, even with no preparation at all, as when explorers land on a hitherto unknown continent, both sides can start to learn each other's language; they know that everyone will pick out as salient middle-sized moving objects, so they can teach each other the word for "rabbit." They understand that it is useless to point to a rabbit which is obscured from the interlocutor's view by a tree. They know that everyone needs food, so they can request it, barter it, and so on.

This is a level of communication which everyone recognizes, and we are not saying anything here with which our mediational opponents will disagree. But this leaves untouched the most difficult kind of differences. Our first level is the universally human, and is closely linked with our similarity as organic beings—in certain cases, even with what we share with the animals. But the intractable differences which seem to defy understanding are at the level of culture, or of the specifically human meanings, which are disclosed in language. Things we might describe in the following ways: the

religion and the rituals of this society seem strange to us, we cannot see why anyone would ever adopt these, they may even be repugnant; or what seems to us their code of honor seems unbalanced: they strain at trivialities and let important things go by; their attitude to death, both their own and that of others, is hard to understand: in our eyes they are too easily willing to inflict death or suffer it; what we might describe as their political system defeats our understanding: they don't seem to have a government at all. As we shall see later, there is a problem with this way of describing the differences, but it can do as a handy fashion of identifying the phenomenon.

Here we are dealing not with what we might call life meanings, which we share as biological creatures, but with meanings on a moral, or an ethical, or a spiritual level, having to do with what are seen as the highest goals, or the best way of life, or moral obligation, or a noble style of being, or virtues of one kind or another. Let's call these "human meanings," because they're the kind of thing we find among humans, as linguistic and cultural beings, and not among the other animals. Of course, these two levels are only notionally separated. In actual human life they are profoundly interwoven, as we shall discuss below.

These human meanings are connected to a point or purpose. And we can fail to see the point. We can perhaps locate it in general terms, as in the above descriptions, where we said that their religion was strange, or their code of honor unbalanced. But this identification doesn't resolve the puzzlement; it just situates it. When my interlocutor flies into a rage at some (to me) anodyne remark, I can't see for the life of me what there is here which damages his honor. The *point d'honneur* here quite escapes me.

Indeed, it can be so opaque that the question arises whether I have located the right general description; maybe it's not a matter of honor at all. More profoundly, maybe this society doesn't have a dimension of concern which corresponds to the term I'm using. Maybe they don't have points of honor. Maybe they don't have a religion, anyway in something like the sense that term has for us. Here we can see why locating what the differences are about can be a far from innocent move, and may quite block further understanding. We will recur to this below.

In any case, on this cultural level, the difficulty is that we are unable at first to see the point of their moral, ethical, or spiritual meanings. And yet we do manage to communicate, at least sometimes. We overcome the barriers and come to see what they're about; whether or not we actually come

to want to espouse this way of life or not, we come to understand what is important to them. How is this possible?

Mediationalism frequently has the effect of making us question whether it really is possible, because it suggests that each culture develops its own scheme defining its human meanings, which the members of that culture cannot escape. Where the schemes are different, communication breaks down. Hence the interdict accepted in certain circles on the Left, until recently, on anyone in a hegemonic position trying to articulate the worldview of someone in a subaltern position, whether it be anthropologists explaining the outlook of the society they had studied, or a man explaining the standpoint of women, etc. There always had to be an illegitimate "appropriation of the voice" of the less powerful by the dominant.

Less radically, even if some understanding is allowed, the mediational picture tends to encourage a kind of relativism. The different standpoints are incommensurable, and there is no reality against which they can be judged. So they cannot be ranked. This can, of course, be the basis of a plea for tolerance, and peaceful coexistence.

In this context, one can see the point of an attempt to establish the possibility of universal communication through an outright rejection of the idea of a conceptual scheme, as famously proposed by Donald Davidson,[4] Rorty's espousal of which we were invoking earlier.[5] Davidson means his argument to be taken as a repudiation of the whole representational epistemology. "In giving up the dualism of scheme and world, we do not give up the world, but re-establish unmediated touch with the familiar objects whose antics make our sentences and opinions true and false."[6]

But we think the Davidsonian rejection of the distinction runs us into incoherence or worse. The standard danger here is ethnocentrism, misunderstanding the other because he or she is interpreted as operating with the same classifications as we are. The differences in behavior are then often simply coded as bad versus good.

4. Donald Davidson, "On the Very Idea of a Conceptual Scheme," in *Inquiries into Truth and Interpretation* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1984), chapter 13.

5. Rorty, *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature*.

6. This phrase makes unambiguously clear Davidson's rejection of strand (1) of the composite picture of mediationalism. But the picture hangs on, as we argued above, in the other strands. Donald Davidson, "On the Very Idea," 198.

We believe that a more adequate account of the difference, and how it can be bridged, is found in Gadamer's account of intercultural understanding. "Understanding is always the process of a fusion of horizons supposedly existing for themselves" (*Verstehen [ist] immer der Vorgang der Verschmelzung . . . vermeintlich für sich seiender Horizonte*).[7]

Gadamer's concept "horizon" is something like our notion of "background"; it designates the surrounding context within which the particular things we do, say, ask, bring about, have the sense they do. But the notion of the background itself can be applied at different levels. There is a background understanding underlying our everyday coping as bodily beings in our surroundings, which we have described in the previous chapters, and by which we make sense of our surroundings as figure and ground, zones of confinement and zones of openness, obstacles and facilitations. This kind of background is shared by human beings generally, and is articulated around the life meanings.

But we can also speak of the background understanding of a given culture, that is, the general understanding of what matters in human life, in the context of which things have the ethical, moral, and spiritual point that they do. For certain aboriginal societies, the extreme importance they attribute to certain places, their refusal to trade them for other (to us rootless and globalized economic agents) even more favorable places (so that, say, we can drill for oil under their original home), can only be understood if we can grasp the way in which their very identity is defined by this mountain, say, which in turn makes sense only because of their relation to the spirit world and its nature.

We take Gadamer's notion of horizon to be referring, anyway in this context, to a general understanding of this latter, cultural sort. But the concept has a complexity and a flexibility which are essential to it. On one hand, horizons can be identified and distinguished; it is through such distinctions that we can come to grasp what is distorting understanding and impeding communication. But on the other hand, horizons evolve, change. There is no such thing as a fixed horizon. "The horizon is, rather, something into which we move and which moves with us. Horizons change for a person who

7. Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Wahrheit und Methode* (Tübingen: Mohr, 1975), 289. *Truth and Method*, trans. Joel Weinsheimer, 2nd rev. ed. (New York: Continuum, 2004), 304.

is moving" (*Der Horizont ist vielmehr etwas, in das wir hineinwandern und das mit uns mitwandert. Dem Beweglichen verschieben sich die Horizonte*).[8] A horizon with unchanging contours is an abstraction. Horizons identified by the agents whose worlds they circumscribe are always in movement. The horizons of A and B may thus be distinct at time t, and their mutual understanding very imperfect. But A and B by living together may come to have a single common horizon at t + n.

In this way "horizon" functions somewhat like "language." We can talk about the "language of modern liberalism," or the "language of nationalism," and point out the things they cannot comprehend. But these are abstractions, freeze-frames of a continuing film. If we talk about the language of Americans or Frenchmen, we can no longer draw their limits a priori; for the language is identified by the agents, who can evolve.

We can see that this picture of horizons and their potential fusion yields a kind of "principle of charity": my interlocutor can't be totally wrong, nor can I, because we are inescapably in contact with reality, and can alter our "take" on it. But for all the surface similarities to Davidson's view, the arguments are really quite different. Gadamer's is ontologically based: human beings are in contact with the real. Davidson's is epistemological: the condition of my understanding you as you think and act in your terms is that I construe you as making sense in my terms most of the time. This has indeed the classical form of an antirealist thesis: in face of a commonsense distinction which seems to threaten us with irremediable ignorance about some important matter, take the bold step of denying the distinction.

The commonsense distinction in this case is that two societies or cultures may understand and make sense of their lives in very different ways. The disturbing possibility is that they may never be able to understand each other, may remain forever locked inside their own ways of sense-making. At its most disturbing, the prospect is that there is a human but alien culture which we can never grasp. What life is for them is ultimately unknowable to us. The antirealist response is to deny the distinction itself: there is no such thing as different, mutually irreducible ways of making sense of life, and therefore nothing which could even potentially play the role of unknowable object.

8. Gadamer, *Wahrheit und Methode*, 288. *Truth and Method*, 303.

We might think that the basis for charity doesn't count, that what matters is the conclusion. But in fact, the two principles have a fatefully different impact on the important issues of intercultural difference.

Davidson's argument against the idea that we could be imprisoned in utterly incongruent schemes is obviously a powerful one. Davidson's principle of charity requires that I, the observer/theorist, must make sense of him, the subject studied, in the sense of finding most of what he does, thinks, and says intelligible; else I can't be treating him as a rational agent, and there is nothing to understand, in the relevant sense, at all.

What this argument shows is that total unintelligibility of another culture is not an option. For to experience another group as unintelligible over some range of their practices, we have to find them quite understandable over other (very substantial) ranges. We have to be able to understand them as framing intentions, carrying out actions, trying to communicate orders, truths, etc. If we imagine even this away, then we no longer have the basis which allows us to recognize them as agents. But then there's nothing left to be puzzled about. Concerning non-agents, there is no question about what they're up to, and hence no possibility of being baffled on this score.

And clearly this kind of total noncomprehension is not possible for human beings. We can always count on instant communication around our nature as bodily agents, and the shared life needs, as we pointed out above. But the problem with Davidson's argument is that it is in a sense too powerful. It slays the terrifying mythical beast of total and irremediable incomprehensibility. But what we suffer from in our real encounters between peoples are the jackals and vultures of partial and (we hope) surmountable noncommunication.

In this real-life situation, Davidson's theory is less useful, mainly because it seems to discredit the idea of "conceptual schemes" altogether—this in spite of the fact that the argument only rules out our meeting a totally unintelligible one. But in dealing with the real, partial barriers to understanding, we need to be able to identify what is blocking us. And for this we need some way of picking out the systematic differences in construal between two different cultures, without either reifying these differences or branding them as ineradicable. This is because of two factors at play here: (1) what is blocking us is our failure to see the point of the human meanings they respond to, and (2) these meanings are interrelated in a gestalt holism; we can

only understand particular points in relation to the broader sense of what is ultimately important.

This is what is taken into account in Gadamer's image of the horizon. Horizons can be different, but at the same time they can travel, change, extend—as you climb a mountain, for instance. It is what Davidson's position as yet lacks.

Without this, Davidson's principle of charity is vulnerable to being abused to ethnocentric ends. The principle tells me to make the best sense I can of the other's words and deeds. In translating his words into my language, I should render him so that as much as possible he speaks the truth, makes valid inferences, etc. But the issue is to know what counts as "my language" here. It can mean the language I speak at the moment of encounter. Or it can mean the extended language, the one that emerges from my attempts to understand him, to fuse horizons with him. If we take it in the first way, it is almost certain that I will ethnocentrically distort him.

For the problem is that the standing ethnocentric temptation is to make too quick sense of the stranger, that is, sense in one's own terms. The lesser breeds are without the law, because they have nothing we recognize as law. The step to branding them as lawless and outlaw is as easy as it is invalid and fateful. Thus when the Conquistadores met the Aztecs these hard-bitten, unscrupulous adventurers were deeply shaken by the Aztecs' practice of human sacrifice. For the more unsophisticated Spaniards, the only possible account of this was that the Aztecs worshipped the devil. "It's simple, *compadres*, you either worship God or the devil. Ripping out hearts, is that worshipping God?? It follows . . ."

The problem with Davidson's approach is that it allows us to forget, or to fail to appreciate from the beginning, how deeply we are failing to get the point of what they do. It allows us too easily to assume that the points of their actions are already available to us in our repertory of sense.

What is needed is not the Davidsonian "principle of charity"—which means: make the best sense of them in what we understand as sense—but rather: coming to understand that there is a very different way of understanding human life, the cosmos, the holy, etc. Somewhere along the line, you need some place in your ontology for something like "the Aztec way of seeing things," in contrast to "our way of seeing things"—in short, something like the scheme-content distinction. To fail to make this can be, literally, lethal.

Of course, this kind of ethnocentrism totally violates Davidson's intent. But the problem is that we need to understand how we move from our language at the time of encounter, which can only distort them, to a richer language which has place for them, from making the "best sense" in our initial terms, which will usually be an alien imposition, to making the best sense within a fused horizon. We can't see how we can conceive of or carry out this process without allowing into our ontology something like alternative horizons or conceptual schemes. This we think marks the superiority of Gadamer's view over Davidson's.

But Davidson's argument is nonetheless very valuable, in pointing out the dangers, even the paradoxes, involved in using any such terms. We can see this when we ask the question, what does the concept "scheme" contrast with? The term "content" is certainly very bad—as though there were stuff already lying there, to be framed in different schemes. There is certainly a deep problem here.

It belongs to the very idea of a scheme, in the sense one is tempted to use it in intercultural studies, that it indicate some systematic way in which people are interpreting or understanding their world. Different schemes are such incompatible ways of understanding the same things.

But what things? runs the objection. How can you point to the things in question? If you use the language of the target society to get at them, then all distinction between scheme and content disappears. But what else can you use? Well, let's say our language, that of us the observers/scientists, about this target area. But then we still won't have got at the "content" we share in common, which would have to be somehow identifiable independently of both schemes.

The point is well taken; and it needs to be kept in mind in order to avoid certain easy pitfalls, such as thinking that one has a neutral, universal categorization of the structures or functions of all societies ("political system," "family," "religion," etc.) which provides the ultimately correct description for what all the different fumbling, cultural languages are aiming at—as it were, the noumena to their phenomenal tongues. But the notion of two schemes, one target area, remains valid and, indeed, indispensable.

Let's go back to the case of the Conquistadores and the Aztecs. We might say that one thing the Conquistadores had right was that they recognized that all that ripping out of hearts in some way corresponded in Spanish society to the Church and the Mass, and that sort of thing. That is, the right insight, yielding a good starting point for an eventual fusion of horizons,

involves identifying what something in the puzzling life of an alien people can usefully be contrasted with in ours. In Gadamerian terms, what we are doing is identifying that facet of our lives which their strange customs interpolate, challenge, offer a notional alternative to.

An example will show what is at stake here. A few years ago a wildly reductivistic American social scientist produced a theory of Aztec sacrifice in which it was explained "materialistically" in terms of their need for protein.[9] On this view the right point of comparison in Spanish society would be their slaughterhouses rather than their churches. Needless to say, from such a starting point, one gets nowhere.

The fruitful supposition is that what went on atop those pyramids reflected a very different construal of an X which overlaps with what Christian faith and practice is a construal of in Spain. This is where thinking, inquiry, can usefully start. It has one very powerful—and in principle challengeable—presupposition: that we share the same humanness, and that therefore we can ultimately find our feet in Aztec sacrifice, because it's a way of dealing with a human condition we share. Once this is accepted, then the notion of two schemes, same X, becomes inescapable. Only we have to be careful what we put in the place of the "X."

In a general proposition, we might say: dimension, or aspect of the human condition. In the particular case, it is much more dangerous to specify. "Religion" would be an obvious candidate word. But the danger is precisely that we happily take on board everything which this word means in our world, and slide back towards the ethnocentric reading of the Conquistadores. So we perhaps retreat to something vaguer, like "numinous." But even this carries its dangers.

The point is to beware of labels here. This is the lesson to be learned from attacks on the scheme-content distinction. But that the Mass and Aztec sacrifice belong to rival construals of a dimension of the human condition for which we have no stable, culture-transcendent name, is a thought we cannot let go of, unless we want to relegate these people to the kind of unintelligibility that members of a different species would have for us. If rejecting the distinction means sliding into this, it is hardly an innocent step.

9. Marvin Harris. *Cannibals and Kings: The Origins of Cultures.* (New York: Random House, 1977), 182.

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We can see from this Gadamer-Davidson comparison that Gadamer has identified what we lack when we stare uncomprehending across a cultural gap. (1) We can't grasp the point of what they do, and (2) we will only be able to do this when we can understand the general shape of their sense of what things are ultimately or crucially important. But the word "scheme" can be misleading for this, not just in the way explored in the last section, but also because it seems to imply that this sense is formulated exclusively in concepts or propositions.

But this is crucially wrong. It seems to be the case that a people couldn't organize their lives around a given sense of the ultimately important without conceptual formulations; but it is very far from being the case that they exclusively do so. Rather this sense exists in what we called above a "multimedia" formulation. At one level, we have what Bourdieu calls "habitus," the way we can be trained to hold ourselves, stand in the presence of others, address them in a certain tone, and the like. For instance, we train our youth to stand respectfully before their elders, to bow at appropriate moments, not to raise their voices, to use certain forms of address. In all this, they learn to respect, even revere, their parents and elders. Or women are trained always to look at the ground in the company of men, never to look them straight in the face, etc., hence to assume a subordinate position, and not to challenge them.[10]

But learning this kind of habitus is not just a matter of learning certain movements. It is learning certain social meanings through such training. Thus the kids would not have learned if they didn't get the point that certain appropriate feelings and attitudes go along with this demeanor, that certain valuations are consonant with their way of acting and others not. Thus, if I, as a young person, am filled with contempt for my elders even as I conform, I recognize right off that this is something I must hide, that I am in fact dissimulating as I bow, that there is some conflict within me as I go on conforming to the norms—that I am an inner rebel.

Another way of seeing this point is that I don't conform just by making movements of a certain neutral description. The movements are meant to embody respect. That's why there are ways of carrying them through in such

10. Bourdieu, *Le Sens Pratique* (Paris: Minuit, 1980).

a perfunctory or even jaunty fashion that I am actually being cheeky, and hence violating the norm.

So the habitus here is a medium of expression of certain human meanings, defining a certain social world with its constitutive sense of what is important. It is also what integrates me into this social world, and makes those meanings manifest and real for me, as a child growing up. And there are other modes of expression/integration/manifestation. These include "theoretical" statements about older people, that they are worthy of respect, and why; they include: symbols and recognized symbolic connections, headdresses of elders, rituals they engage in, etc; and they also include: stories people tell, legends, cautionary tales, etc. All of these interpenetrate and mutually affect each other. The kind of respect I feel, as a well-brought-up boy, will be deeply colored by that story of an exemplary elder, and the love and admiration his children showed him, which deeply impressed me as a child; by some striking formulations of the idea that men grow wiser; by some saintly figure I met when I was a mere kid. We have here what we described in Chapter 2 as a multimedia grasp on meanings.

This interweaving of the bodily, the symbolic, and the narrative and propositional illustrates what we said above about the inseparability of the life and human meanings in the stream of human existence. The habitus itself, a bodily comportment which is the expression/manifestation of the most important social meanings, shows how the two levels are welded together. On one level, we can describe our maintaining equilibrium as our finding our footing in the gravitational field, which empowers us to act, move about, manipulate things. But from the very beginning of human life, this upright posture also becomes the site of human meanings, of understandings of dignity, for instance (as against the "humiliation" of being forced close to the ground), or of our relation to something higher, to heaven, say; and this can be developed and embroidered in different ways in a philosophy or a theology.[11]

11. This investment by human meanings of the body shows how it is possible *both* to say that there are universally recognizable human needs and actions, based on our common biological constitution, *and* that each culture transforms all our bodily gestures and actions in line with the human meanings it defines, as some philosophers, such as Merleau-Ponty and Foucault, have claimed. Even the most "basic" actions—how people eat, how they express sexual desire, how they enter into conversation with each other—partake of a

The body is, in particular, the site of social meanings, because of what we can call intercorporeality, the ways in which our bodies are attuned to each other from the very beginning of human life. A baby imitates the smile of her mother's face, well before she can grasp by observation her own face, and see the likeness of her expression to the mother's. In Merleau-Ponty's example, "a fifteen-month-old baby opens his mouth when I playfully take one of his fingers in my mouth and pretend to bite it. And yet, he has hardly even seen his face in a mirror and his teeth do not resemble mine. His own mouth and teeth such as he senses them from within are immediately for him the instruments for biting, and my jaw such as he sees it from the outside is for him immediately capable of the same intentions" (*un bébé de quinze mois ouvre la bouche si je prends par jeu l'un de ses doigts entre les dents et que je fasse mine de mordre. Et pourtant, il n'a guère regardé son visage dans une glace, ses dents ne ressemblent pas aux miennes. C'est que sa propre bouche et ses dents, telles qu'il les sent de l'intérieur, sont d'emblée pour lui des appareils à mordre, et que ma mâchoire, telle qu'il la voit du dehors, est d'emblée pour lui capable des mêmes intentions*).[12] The sense of possible intentions in one's own body and the perception of these in others are primordially understood as belonging to the same type, and the likeness is lived in the communion of a two-person game, before it is grasped as a classification. We are readied from the beginning to enter into dialogical rhythms and common actions with others, playing endlessly repetitive games of hiding and revealing, of concealment and surprise, and this prepares the ground for the future postures of intimacy and distance, of common action and separate projects, which shape the geography of later social life.

We mentioned in Chapter 5 that the different stances of disengagement were elaborated in language. We can extend that to the full range of human

different style in different cultures, and the outsider is always in danger of making the most egregious faux pas. Nevertheless we rarely have trouble recognizing the kind of action it is on this "basic" level, so much do the styles come across as variations on a common theme. We usually know that they're eating, or even looking hungrily at food—however different, for instance, are the styles of polite eating (quietly here, slurping and burping there), or the rules of commensality—or how eating relates to their human meanings (culture A has an important place for sacred meals, culture B not at all).

12. Merleau-Ponty, *Phénoménologie de la Perception*, 404. *Phenomenology of Perception*, 368.

meanings—moral, political, aesthetic, religious. But in saying this, we have to be taking language in a broad enough sense to include those bodily practices which reflect and embody these meanings, such as the bowing of our youth above. Language in this broad sense groups the ensemble of media which have constitutive force, that is, which can make meanings manifest for us. As we argued in Chapter 2, human meaning is in fact embedded in the whole gamut of media, in declarative speech, story, symbol, in rules, and in habitus.

And here we connect with the Gadamerian thesis that the world we live in, the human meanings we experience, are essentially constituted in language, in the broad sense of the previous paragraph. This is the Gadamerian thesis of "linguisticality" or *Sprachlichkeit.*

The broad sense of "language" we are forced to use here (or else we must use another term, but with this wide meaning) points up another problem with the term "conceptual scheme." The differences between human cultures can't be tracked simply at the level of the descriptive concepts which figure in their languages, in the narrow (ordinary) sense. This seems to be what Davidson is assuming in his discussion that we cited above.[13] "Incommensurable schemes" would have to mean "not intertranslatable" languages.[14] But if we think of two speakers who face a world whose features are equally accessible to both, in virtue of similar capacities of perception, identification, etc., it is hard to imagine a serious case of real non-intertranslatability. Suppose my interlocutor does classify things differently; suppose he says, "Look at that handsome yawl," as the boat sails by, where he should have said "ketch" using standard English. If his line of sight is good, and it is likely that he "has made no mistake at all about the position of the jigger on the passing yacht," I just assume that he suffers from a form of malapropism, and that "ketch" in ordinary parlance has become "yawl" in his lexicon.[15] Translation has been achieved.

But once we take account of the discussion in Chapter 5, and see how rather different genres of discourse and language games come to develop in the course of human history, once we see that these language games invoke

13. Davidson, "On the Very Idea."

14. Ibid., 190.

15. Ibid., 196.

meanings which are expressed and manifested in a broader range of media than just descriptive prose, we can see how fragile the assumption is that speakers face a world whose features are equally accessible to all. This may be true of what J. L. Austin called "medium-sized dry goods," but what about the Persian visitor, who thought he was competent in Greek, who hears Socrates interrogating Thrasymachus (or the unsophisticated visitor from Magara, for that matter)? What about the Spaniards discovering Aztec sacrifice? They can be given a word: "this is dialectic," or "this is N (whatever the Nahuatl word is for this activity)." But this doesn't help, certainly doesn't help enough, because there is still something baffling about what this is supposed to describe—the activity itself, or the descriptions of things (like "aporia," or "proper sacrificial victim") which figure in the activity.

But, it might be objected, we can't expect these strangers to know everything. Just being baffled can't be a sufficient condition for non-intertranslatability. We are often out of our depth when we enter special milieu even in our own culture. In a chemical laboratory, or a cyclotron, I would be totally out of it, unable to understand what people were saying. We don't see a cultural gap here, because I presumably understand in general terms what post-Galilean science is all about,; how it yields a deeper grasp on the processes which go on in medium-sized dry goods. I know how to place this exchange, even if I lack the specialized knowledge to follow it. (But we do sometimes speak with C. P. Snow of "two cultures" here,[16] when we want to emphasize broad differences in outlook and value between people trained in science and the humanities.)

In other words, we—unlike a medieval peasant suddenly entering our century through some time warp—understand what the point of this activity is. But that is just what escapes the Persian and the Spaniard in our examples. This difference is certainly reflected in descriptive terms which are non-intertranslatable, like "dialectic" and "aporia," or (the Nahuatl terms we roughly translate as) "sacrifice" and "victim." But the differences are linguistic at a deeper level. The activities themselves are constituted in language, in certain forms of discourse or exchange, before, or perhaps simultaneously with, their description. We could imagine that when Socrates started his

16. C. P. Snow, *The Two Cultures and the Scientific Revolution* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1959).

(irritating and challenging) mode of questioning, the term "dialectic" had not yet been coined. Perhaps in fact it was Plato who coined it later. The Aztec sacrifice that shocked Cortés and his men evolved out of ritual languages, rich interweavings of gesture, symbol, and verbal exchange, which had come to express/constitute certain meanings in human-divine relations.

Learning another language can't just be coming to master a descriptive lexicon for the things which lie before us, equally accessible to all human beings. There are such things—rabbits, elephants, trees, hands, feet, edible fruit—and they tremendously help communication on first encounter. But that's not all there is to mutual understanding. Deep incommensurability, or non-intertranslatability,[17] comes when we can't make sense of big segments of their discourse, or of some of their crucial language games. To go beyond this, we need to grasp something which goes way beyond what we could ever puzzle out by comparing their descriptive vocabulary to the world-as-it-is-accessible-to-us; we have to grasp how in the whole range of media they constitute human meanings, some of which are initially very foreign to us.

Thus some of their words may be very hard to construe, because they don't just belong to but crucially help constitute certain of their central practices. Take an example which has been very important to us politically: the type of régime which has come down to us from the Greek polis (and to some extent also the Roman Republic), where there is a fundamental equality between the citizens qua citizens, equality which is essential to their conception of free self-rule and a free people. This type of régime is impossible without there being some formulation of the demand for equality, without this becoming a term of assessment, held to apply to certain societies, or certain contexts, and not others. We could imagine certain kinds of primitive society where what we could call equality could exist unformulated, but not

17. Of course, that a term in L can't be translated into L' is something which holds only for L' at a certain time (where L' is a natural language). This is so because languages can neologize and can be extended and developed, as we saw. It is significant that some of the concepts from cultures rather far from ours enter our language through our domesticating the word, along with ethnographic explanations. Words like *mana*, *tabu*, and *seppuku* illustrate this. Of course, just taking over their word may not help, as we see with the case of *tabu*, which we bandy around freely in a way which has little relation to the original Polynesian. See Marshall Sahlins, *Social Stratification in Polynesia* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1958).

for example a Greek polis, where equality was bound up with the norms for who should rule and how, and where it thus had to be recognized in some form as a norm.

Thus the Spartans describing themselves as the Equals (*homoioi*), the norm of *isêgoria* in democracies, the battle around *isonomia*, and the like are not accessory features which we could imagine having been quite absent while those societies remained essentially what they were. The self-description as equals is an essential part of this régime, that is, of this relation of equality, and this because the régime requires a degree of explicit common understanding which is impossible without self-description.

This is an example of what we could call the constitutive dimension of language. There are ways in which the language we use enters into, is an essential part of, our feelings, our goals, our social relations and practices. The aspect of language which is essential in this way may be purely an expressive aspect in some cases, such as when modes of address carry the burden of marking the kinds of footing we are on with each other. But it may also be that what is essential to a given feeling or relation is certain descriptions.

This is what we see in the case of the polis. Self-description as equals is essential to the régime. And this not in virtue of some merely causal condition, as one might say that relative isolation or an infrastructure of slave labor were essential to these régimes. Rather the point is that this kind of practice of equality essentially requires the explicit recognition of equality. It would not be classifiable as this practice without that recognition, without the participants holding each other to it as a norm.

Put another way, the norm can't be understood independently of a certain set of practices, here of citizen self-rule; and the practices are unthinkable without the norm. Without grasping this constitutive relation, the outside observer has no adequate sense of the descriptive meaning.

Visitors from some totally despotic culture, dropped into classical Athens, we keep hearing people using this word "equal," and its companion "like" (*isos*, *homoios*). We know how to apply these words to sticks, stones, perhaps also houses and ships; for there is a tolerably exact translation in our home language (let's say Persian again). And we also know some ways of applying them to human beings, for instance physical likeness or equality of height. But there is a peculiar way these Hellenes have of using the words which baffles us. Indeed, they have a pugnacious and perverse way of

applying them to human beings who seem to us not at all alike, some tall and some short, some of noble birth, some base, and so on.

What we have to grasp is how these words get their grip in politics. Maybe it is not hard for us to see that these short, base men are refusing to knuckle under to the taller nobility. That much will be evident from the aggressive gestures, and perhaps the actual fighting which goes on. But what we cannot yet grasp is the perceived positive value of this mode of life. Indeed, this conflict can appear to us as just strife, a sign of impending breakdown; we cannot see a different and viable mode of life here at all. (Similarly, some early eighteenth-century Frenchmen thought that England must be on the verge of breakdown, once it allowed the insanely contradictory institution of "His Majesty's Loyal Opposition.")

We have to grasp the ideal of a people of free agents, that is, one in which none of the full participants just takes orders from someone, which agents must therefore rule themselves, and yet which have the courage, initiative, and patriotism to get it together when they have to fight for their freedom. These agents exercise their right to deliberate together about what they will do, but the right to talk does not make them any less effective as agents and warriors when it comes to act.[18] We do not yet see, in other words, the nobility of this kind of life, or what its practitioners identify as noble, their conception of the dignity of a man (here they very much meant men, free adult males) residing in his being this kind of agent, having this kind of freedom.

A similar point could be made in connection with certain of their uses of the word "freedom." Let us take another observer, hostile to the polis, writing many centuries later in defense of a despotic order. The notion of freedom, as a status within a certain kind of practice of self-rule, seemed to him utterly devoid of sense. Freedom could only mean the absence of physical obstacles, and this might be extended to include the absence of legal prohibitions.[19]

What our Persian observer could not see, and what Hobbes would not see, is the way in which "equal," "like," "free," and such terms as "citizen" help define a horizon of value. They articulate the citizens' sensitivity to the

18. Cf. Pericles' funeral oration in Thucydides, *Peloponnesian War*, Book II, 34–6.
19. Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), chap. 21.

standards intrinsic to this ideal and way of life. These articulations are constitutive of this way of life, and therefore we cannot understand it unless we understand these terms.

But reciprocally, we cannot understand these terms unless we grasp what kind of sensitivity they are articulating. They cannot be understood simply on the representational model, as potential descriptions of an independent reality—predicates which can be "satisfied" or not by certain independently existing objects. They function, true, to describe certain social conditions and relations. But these conditions and relations only exist because the agents involved recognize certain concerns, defined in a certain way; they could not sustain just these relations and states if they did not. But the terms are themselves essential to these concerns, under this definition, being recognized. It is through them that the horizon of concern of the agents in question is articulated in the way it must be for just these practices, conditions, relations to exist.

Hence to understand what these terms represent, to grasp them in their representative function, we have to understand them in their articulating-constitutive function. We have to see how they can bring a certain horizon of concern to a certain articulation.

How do we manage to do this? There is no formula; but one thing that should be evident is that one cannot make any headway unless one engages with the people concerned. In order to penetrate their discourse, one has to start trying to hold discourse with them. These exchanges will be rather primitive at first, centered on the equally accessible things; but only through them can we approach exchanges which will get closer to those in which their human meanings are constituted. That is what is deeply mistaken in the way that Quine and Davidson pose the problem of language learning. "Radical translation" (Quine) or "radical interpretation" (Davidson) supposes a learning situation in which the learner observes what the speaker says, as well as its context, and what precedes and follows it. The stance is the same as that of the practitioner of science: observer to object. We could just see this working, if the task were to calibrate their vocabulary for medium-sized dry goods with our own, but never if we're trying to understand what ends and meanings give point to their lives and practices. The insistence that "our actual scheme and language are best understood as extensional and materialist"[20] also makes sense on this restrictive assumption about our goal,

but it is hard to see even what it could mean if our aim is to understand what they're about.

This is where Gadamer's approach is greatly superior. Gadamer makes central the paradigm of a "conversation," in his understanding of human science, rather than that of an inquiring subject studying an object. Success comes, not with an adequate theory of the object, but with the "fusion of horizons," as we said above. This view fully takes account of the point made in the previous paragraph, that we can only bridge certain gaps in understanding by engaging with the relevant others. Moreover, this exchange has to be on some more or less level footing, or it risks serious distortion. And third, in the process of understanding, both sides can well find their previous self-understandings challenged and upset.

This last result will often arise, because in coming to understand activities with a point which is initially strange and incomprehensible, we will often upset our implicit notions of what is "normal" or humanly possible. The cultural pictures which held us captive about the range of human possibility will have to go if we are to accommodate this new way of being without distorting it. We come to see that just understanding this sacrifice as worshipping the Devil is blocking us, and at once this catchall account of strange religions has to be abandoned. Our typology is blown wide open.

In general we might say that in order to get over the distortion, we have to see that there were other possibilities, that our way of being isn't the only or "natural" one, but that it represents one among other possible forms. We can no longer relate to our way of doing or construing things "naïvely," as just too obvious to mention.

If understanding the other is to be construed as fusion of horizons and not as possessing a science of the object, then the slogan might be: no understanding the other without a changed understanding of self.

The kind of understanding that ruling groups have of the ruled, that conquerors have of the conquered—most notably in recent centuries in the far-flung European empires—has usually been based on a quiet confidence that the terms they need are already in their vocabulary. Much of the "social science" of the last century is in this sense just another avatar of an ancient human failing. And indeed, the satisfactions of ruling, beyond the booty, the unequal exchange, the exploitation of labor, very much includes the reaffirmation of one's identity which comes from being able to live this fiction without meeting brutal refutation.

a feature of tomorrow's world (we hope) that this cost will now be less unequally distributed.

The cost appears as such from the standpoint of the antecedent identity, of course. It may be judged a gain once one has gone through the change. We are also enriched by knowing what other human possibilities there are in our world. It cannot be denied, however, that the path to acknowledging this is frequently painful.

The crucial moment is the one where we allow ourselves to be interpolated by the other—where the difference escapes from its categorization as an error, a fault, or a lesser, undeveloped version of what we are, and challenges us to see it as a viable human alternative. It is this which unavoidably calls our own self-understanding into question. This is the stance Gadamer calls "openness," as against the way I stand to what I see as an object of science, where I try "reflecting [myself] out of [my] relation to the other and so becoming unreachable by him" (*sich selber aus der Beziehung zum anderen herauszureflektieren und dadurch von ihm unerreichbar zu warden*),[21] "Openness to the other . . . involves recognizing that I myself must accept some things that are against me, even though no one else forces me to do so" (*Offenheit für den anderen schliesst . . . die Anerkennung ein, dass ich in mir etwas gegen mich gelten lassen muss, auch wenn es keinen anderen gäbe, der es gegen mich geltend machte*).[22]

Gadamer in challenging the subject-object model of human science with his "conversation" paradigm has shown the crucial importance of equal exchange if there is to be a real surmounting of cultural barriers.[23]

3

In addition, the confidence, one might say faith, in our capacity to communicate with each other, even across great differences of culture, arises on the basis of Gadamer's fundamental thesis of linguisticality (*Sprachlichkeit*). We

21. Gadamer, *Wahrheit und Methode*, 342. *Truth and Method*, 354.

22. Gadamer, *Wahrheit und Methode*, 343. *Truth and Method*, 355.

23. For further discussion, see Charles Taylor, "Understanding the Other: A Gadamerian View on Conceptual Schemes," in *Dilemmas And Connections: Selected Essays*. (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2011), chapter 2.

were only inducted into our home culture through learning a language, in the broad sense adumbrated above. But as human beings we are also capable of learning other languages. So however different and even mutually repugnant are the meanings of our respective worlds, we can always in principle come to understand the other. We say "in principle," because it is obvious that in practice this may be extremely difficult, and that conflict, fear, unequal power, arrogance, and a host of other such obstacles may prevent us doing so here and now.

What underlies the possibility of learning other languages, if indeed we do possess it? For we have to bear in mind that nothing guarantees that we would be able to see the point of just any way of life. We can imagine alien beings whose moral/spiritual meanings, if indeed we can even use these terms, would be quite opaque to us. And in partial ways, we can see something like this inability to understand even between humans. We might be vigorously discussing the beauty of Mozart's late piano concerti, or the spiritual depth of Beethoven's late quartets, and a totally tone-deaf person will be unable to understand or take part in the conversation. We may imagine that the difficulty is insurmountable in this case. But something of the same blank incomprehension might be felt by a neophyte to Western music, even though he or she might be able to fuse horizons with us later.

That we are able to bridge vast gulfs of cultural difference, even though it may require much effort and time, is a remarkable fact that we perhaps don't sufficiently examine and wonder at. Our situation seems to be this: all normal human babies are born with this potential, to be integrated into one or other cultural understanding of human meanings through being inducted into a language and way of life ("language" in the broad sense above). The potential can only be realized through such an induction, hence must be realized in one particular variant. But (1) we know that this child could have been inducted with success in any other culture, if he or she had been brought up there, and (2) he or she can learn a second culture.

This means that, however strongly marked by the expressing/integrating/manifesting forms of one culture, human beings are not imprisoned in them. They are not imprisoned in them, because they retain something of the original capacity to understand and be inducted into any of them. There is here another kind of contact, analogous to the one we have been pointing to in our everyday coping with our world. Just as Johnny, for instance, is not imprisoned in any particular set of beliefs about his surroundings, because

he has this basic capacity, through his primordial commerce with things, to go and check what he has been told, so Sarah is not imprisoned in individualist Western culture, but can go as an anthropologist to the outback and come to understand what it means to have an identity defined by totem animals and sacred geography. The contact here consists in an original and as yet uncanceled human capacity to resonate with certain meanings, those within the human range—a range which could only be defined by seeing into what artificially designed cultural forms human babies could or could not be inducted. (Needless to say, no one will ever make the necessary experiments; and if they proposed to do so, they should be put in jail.)

The "contact" in one case consists of actual dealings with the world, and enables us to get behind our representations (formulated beliefs); in the other case, it consists of a capacity to respond, resonate with, make sense of human meanings; and it enables us to get beyond and beneath, not so much representations—though they are involved here—but a kind of imprinting, whereby a certain range of meanings have become for us the human meanings. And these two abilities are intertwined at their root in our most basic bodily comportments.

We can speculate what underlies this capacity to grasp the human meanings, and a wide range of accounts is available. Some of these focus on an intrinsic human nature, perhaps conceived in evolutionary terms, or else connected to our rational capacities. Others have recourse to something outside ourselves. Starting perhaps from the sense of being related to something beyond and above, a sense which can inhere in our upright posture, they conceive this higher reality in very different ways: as the God invoked in the Jewish-Christian-Muslim tradition, or as Nirvana and the unreality of the self; or the great current of life running through the cosmos, evoked by Wordsworth in one way, and Dostoyevsky in another; and so on through a host of other hypotheses. We will almost certainly find it impossible to settle finally on any one of these; and maybe all are wrong. But the phenomenon they are trying to explain is real and important, and we have a distorted view of the intercultural dialogue if we lose sight of it.

Gadamer writes in the wake of Heidegger's pathbreaking work. His "principle of charity" is informed by a contact theory. Our different worlds are linguistically constituted, but our languages are responding to something, trying to articulate something in the human condition. If we want to say that language or culture, in forming our worlds, mediates our contact

with the universe and with our human nature, we would have to add that our language doesn't exhaust this contact. Rather it arises first, against the background or context of our animal existence, following the urgings of instinct in coming to grips with our surroundings; and second, it comes as a specification of a more general capacity, which can never be totally lost, to be inducted into one or other particular variant of the human meanings.

That is why we are never imprisoned in a single language, why we can find our feet in others, can ultimately make sense of what they are talking about, of the meanings they disclose, even if after much time and effort. We are not imprisoned, because language- and world making are not arbitrary; they are in response to something. This is the point of the Heideggerian image that humans are "the shepherds of Being."[24] And in each case the something in question is not irremediably hidden from other human beings, however puzzling, difficult, and repugnant it seems. At least, this last claim is the object of a kind of humanist faith.

Of course, mutual understanding in this sense doesn't yet amount to a "fusion of horizons" in Gadamer's sense. I can learn a foreign language, or learn to find my feet in another culture, without being able to translate from that language, or explain that culture to my compatriots. Being bilingual or bicultural is one thing, but being able to calibrate one of our languages or cultures on the other is quite another. To say that languages are incommensurable is to say that many things said in one can't be translated into the other. Just the fact that I have learned both doesn't stop them being so.

What Gadamer understood as a "fusion" is a further stage, where we come to be able to situate one set of human meanings in relation to the other, where we can even elaborate a common set of terms in which the different fundamental options of each can be related to the other. In the process, we extend our original home languages, enrich their vocabulary, enlarge their gamut of reference points, so that they become capable of carrying this wider understanding. Anthropology and historiography are full of such attempts at languages of perspicuous contrast, such as the distinction between "shame" and "guilt" cultures, or between gift exchange à la Marcel Mauss and economic exchange.

24. Martin Heidegger, *The Question Concerning Technology, and Other Essays*, trans. William Lovitt (New York: Harper & Row, 1977), 42.

But as these examples indicate, these attempts are always fragile and subject to challenge. We are never completely sure that we haven't distorted one or other of the cultures compared. And it is certainly highly possible that some of these differences will forever resist calibration. Indeed, it is an essential part of the position we adopt, "plural realism," which we shall explain further in Chapter 8, that the possibility of ultimate noncalibration must be kept open. Only time and unremitting effort can tell us what can or cannot be achieved in this area. There are no a priori assurances either way.

But prior to, and as a condition of, any attempted fusion, comes the kind of understanding of the initially strange other, which is grounded in our common ability, as human, linguistic animals, to learn. A "principle of charity" does emerge from this condition, properly understood. It is grounded in a contact theory, and reposes finally on an unproblematic "realism." It can allow for the striking gaps and incommensurabilities which actually show up between human cultures, while making it understandable that we can in fact often come to straddle them, even if we can't go beyond this to fuse them.

The difficulties of Davidson's principle, on the other hand, come from his continued embedding in the mediational picture, so that his proof that there cannot be inaccessible conceptual schemes takes the form of a standard antirealist argument: the conditions of the possibility of our understanding of others' meanings as meanings rules out our even recognizing a radically other conceptual scheme. One has to break the captivity within this mediational picture in order to come to grips in a fruitful way with the issues of intercultural understanding. This is one among many examples of how important it is to identify and escape from this mediational *Bild*, which has become so powerfully entrenched in modern culture.